

Tablets will drive out netbooks, become more mainstream

In a matter of speaking, tablet sales will hit the stratosphere!

In today's day and age, tablets aren't exactly a dime a dozen. They're easy to get, but they aren't exactly cheap or inexpensive, with most of the good tablets still a bit too expensive. Of course, the smartphone industry has eclipsed everything in the consumer electronics domain, and cast a huge shadow on other technology products. But with tablets being a natural extension of smartphones, expect a bombardment of tablets this year that will flood the markets with enough and more brands and models. This abundance of products to choose from will eventually help bring down costs across the board, right from the most inexpensive tablet to the most expensive one. This year is a good time to be a tablet enthusiast, here's why.

The iPad effect

We all know how Apple launched the original iPad back in 2010, which, in many ways, spurred on the tablet industry to accelerate and grow. And just like netbooks, between 2007 and 2009, tablets have captured popular imagination in just a couple of years, and analysts only expect the trend to reach new heights this year. According to investment bank JP Morgan, the iPad's share in the global tablet pie will reduce from a whopping 70.9 per cent in 2011 to a still impressive 62.8 per cent by the end of 2012. JP Morgan also believes that until a Windows 8 tablet debuts, there won't be any serious competitors to the iPad. As far as netbooks go, tablet sales eclipsed netbook sales for the first time last year, and the trend isn't expected to reverse any time soon.

FLASH IS DEAD

Yes, Adobe has officially announced the death of Flash on all mobile devices with immediate effect – Flash for desktop PCs is still alive and well, though. Instead of Flash, Adobe will concentrate on promoting HTML5 technology among mobile app developers. HTML5 will ultimately take over Flash's functionality.

With Apple gearing up for the launch of iPad 3, god only knows what new, innovative features it will bring to the table. And as has always been the case, every other manufacturer will try to ape the Apple tablet, and some may actually succeed in doing so this time around.

Next-gen hardware: Tegra 3, Windows 8 tablets

The best tablets releasing this year will undoubtedly have quad-core processors, almost all of them based on NVIDIA's Tegra 3 chipset. Apart from improved performance, Tegra 3 offers some cool features, prime among which is its sensible use of battery life – apart from four high performance cores, the chip deploys a fifth low-performance core for non-intensive tasks which actually helps extend the tablet's battery life (read more on Tegra 3: bit.ly/vK8WNy). Among the first tablets to sport quad-core processors this year are the ASUS Transformer Prime. The upcoming iPad 3's A6 processor is expected to have four cores as well.

Windows 8 tablets are also scheduled for launch towards the second half of 2012, and quite a few analysts are betting on Microsoft to give Apple's iPad a good run for its money. Expect Windows 8 tablets from vendors like Dell, Samsung, even Nokia, with the refreshing Metro UI and a new perspective on tablets (apart from Apple and Google). And never underestimate the wave of Android 4.0 or ICS tablets hitting you soon. With so much variety and innovation expected, not to mention the improved hardware and performance chops, tablets are all



“In 2012 and beyond, we foresee the consumers fuelling demand and appreciation for security software that secures multiple devices and information across multiple platforms, while making it easy for the consumer to manage.”

David Hall, Regional Consumer Product Marketing Manager, Asia Pacific, Symantec

set to become more than just leisurely companions, or entertainment and media consumption devices.

Low-cost tablets: Aakash and beyond

Just last month, dubbed as the most inexpensive tablet in the world, the low-cost Android 2.2 tablet Aakash went on sale online, and was sold out with DataWind (the manufacturer) receiving close to 30,000 orders of Aakash (priced at ₹2,500) and over 1 million pre-orders for the UbiSlate 7 tablet (Aakash 2) priced at ₹2,999. Even with international success stories like the Amazon Kindle Fire (a US \$200 Android tablet), the potential for low-end, price-conscious tablets to launch with older Android builds (Gingerbread or Honeycomb) is quite high. **d**